Request for Proposals: Monitoring, Evaluation & Learning Consulting Support
September 2026

Friends of the Earth U.S.
Climate-Friendly School Food Program

Anticipated contract period: November 2026–June 30, 2027
Anticipated combined budget: Approximately $80,000–$100,000

Background

Friends of the Earth U.S. (FOE) is seeking consulting support to strengthen the monitoring, evaluation, and learning (MEL) capacity of our Climate-Friendly School Food Program.

The program works to shift K–12 school meals toward more plant-forward and organic menus in order to reduce environmental impacts and improve student health. Our strategies include direct technical assistance to school districts, policy advocacy, plant-based K–12 value chain development, research, student-led school meal campaigns, and resources for school foodservice operators.

As the program has grown over the last decade, so have our MEL needs. We currently collect and analyze school menus, production records, purchasing records, and USDA Foods purchasing data. We have an AI-supported tool to categorize school district menu offerings and have a second tool under development to translate school food purchasing records, production records, and recipe data into environmental and animal impacts. We are also expanding our applied research, moving beyond tracking changes in school meals to designing and testing interventions and pilots to increase student selection of plant-based options and better understand which strategies are most effective. This requires stronger evaluation design, more consistent analytical methods, better data systems and documentation, and clearer processes for translating findings into program decisions.

We are seeking consulting support to make this work more consistent, rigorous, efficient, and sustainable while expanding our capacity to evaluate program outcomes, conduct applied research, and learn from the data we collect.

Consulting Structure

FOE anticipates engaging two complementary consulting functions:

- **Senior MEL & Evaluation Consultant:** Approximately 350 hours over the contract period.
- **MEL Data Analyst:** Approximately 500 hours over the contract period.

FOE has a **strong preference for proposals from consulting firms or established consultant teams that can provide both functions as an integrated team**, with the Senior Consultant responsible for overall methodological direction, coordination, and quality assurance of the Data Analyst's work. We will also accept applications from qualified individuals interested in either role and may contract separately with exceptional candidates.

This is a **hands-on consulting engagement**. The **Senior Consultant** should be equally comfortable developing sound evaluation approaches and digging into messy data to make sense of it. The **Data Analyst** should bring substantial technical capacity and be comfortable using modern analytical, coding, and AI-supported tools to make recurring MEL work more efficient and scalable.

Scope of Work

1. Lead MEL methodology, planning, and quality assurance

Early in the engagement, FOE will participate in an external MEL System Assessment examining the program's MEL foundations, systems, capacity, data practices, and opportunities for improvement. The

Senior Consultant will participate in this process alongside FOE program leadership and use the resulting assessment, together with their own review of existing MEL approaches, data, and workflows, to inform priorities for the engagement.

The Senior Consultant will then translate these findings and FOE's program priorities into a practical, prioritized MEL workplan.

Responsibilities will include:

- Participate in FOE's external MEL System Assessment and help interpret its findings and implications for the Climate-Friendly School Food Program.
- Review the program's existing MEL framework, methodologies, data practices, and analytical workflows and identify priority areas for strengthening, building on rather than duplicating the external assessment.
- Develop a prioritized MEL workplan and associated deliverables in consultation with FOE.
- Establish and apply consistent quality-assurance standards, including for analyses supported by AI tools.
- Review and strengthen existing methodologies where needed, including approaches to measuring student selection and displacement, sampling, comparison groups and counterfactuals, data inclusion and exclusion criteria, sensitivity analyses, and extrapolation.
- Ensure that methods and resulting claims are appropriately rigorous and defensible for their intended uses, including program learning, funder reporting, advocacy, and public communications.
- Resolve methodological and data-quality issues where possible and bring FOE clear recommendations when strategic decisions are needed.
- Provide methodological direction and quality assurance for work performed by the Data Analyst.

The Senior Consultant will serve as FOE's primary external MEL partner, translating program priorities into practical measurement and evaluation activities and ensuring the methodological quality of the work.

The Data Analyst will support this work through implementation of analytical protocols, documentation, data-quality checks, and preparation of analyses and outputs.

2. Support and progressively assume responsibility for evaluation of the Plant Powered Participation Pilot

FOE's Plant Powered Participation Pilot (4P) is a seven-district pilot testing strategies for increasing student selection of plant-based and plant-forward entrées. The pilot will already be underway when this engagement begins. FOE will have established the core pilot design, participating districts, research questions, interventions, and primary data-collection approach.

The Senior Consultant will become familiar with the existing evaluation design and progressively assume substantial responsibility for analysis, interpretation, and reporting. Early in the engagement, the Senior Consultant will review and document the existing evaluation approach, identify any methodological or data-quality issues that can still feasibly be addressed, and develop a clear analysis and reporting plan for the remainder of the pilot. The consultant team will ultimately be responsible for synthesizing the pilot's findings and sharing practical recommendations for future technical assistance, intervention design, and program strategy.

Responsibilities will include:

- Participate in district meetings as needed to understand pilot implementation, data availability, and relevant operational context. FOE staff will continue to lead district relationships and provide school foodservice expertise.
- Review the existing pilot design, research questions, metrics, data-collection approach, menus, baseline information, intervention plans, and other relevant documentation to understand the evaluation and identify any gaps or limitations.
- Identify confounding factors, data gaps, and other limitations that should be addressed where feasible or accounted for in the analysis and interpretation of findings.
- Oversee the collection, analysis, and interpretation of production records, recipes, cost information, and other pilot data.
- Analyze and interpret findings at both the individual-district and cross-district levels, including variation in implementation and outcomes across participating districts.
- Produce district-level findings and recommendations and an overarching pilot report synthesizing findings, limitations, lessons learned, and recommendations for future work.

The Data Analyst will support this work by organizing, cleaning, standardizing, and validating pilot data; operating relevant AI-supported and analytical tools; conducting analyses and sensitivity checks; and producing tables, visualizations, and other analytical outputs.

3. Conduct recurring and district-specific MEL analyses

The consulting team will conduct, strengthen, and help systematize several existing and emerging areas of program monitoring and analysis. Priorities and specific deliverables will be refined through the initial MEL assessment and work planning process, but anticipated areas of work include:

- **Annual menu monitoring:** FOE has conducted recurring analyses of school district menus to track the availability, frequency, and variety of entrée offerings, including plant-based options, and changes over time. FOE has developed an AI-supported menu analysis tool to help scale this work. The consulting team will review and strengthen the existing methodology; support quality assurance and validation of AI-generated results; conduct or oversee annual analyses; assess trends over time; produce written summaries and data visualizations; and recommend improvements including to further automate aspects of the analysis.
- **District-level food purchasing records:** Analyze district purchasing records to assess changes in protein procurement, costs, and associated environmental and animal impacts over time.
- **Student selection and participation:** Analyze school production records and recipes to assess student selection of plant-based and plant-forward entrées and beverages and estimate associated environmental and animal impacts using established life cycle assessment methodologies, as well as costs and effects on overall school meal participation. This may include developing appropriate comparison or counterfactual approaches for district-specific pilots and interventions.
- **USDA Foods:** Analyze federal USDA Foods purchasing and allocation data to better understand the types and quantities of foods flowing through the program, including patterns in protein purchasing and implications for FOE's school food strategies.

The consulting team will also work to integrate statewide menu monitoring with more detailed production record and recipe analyses from a sample of districts to estimate statewide trends and impacts, including

changes in greenhouse gas emissions, water use, and impacts on animals associated with shifts in school meal offerings and student selection.

The Senior Consultant will determine or refine analytical approaches, review and quality-assure the work, personally investigate underlying data where necessary, interpret findings, and lead development of substantive and actionable analytical products (e.g., memos, reports, and data visualizations).

The Data Analyst will take substantial responsibility for organizing, cleaning, and standardizing datasets; operating existing AI and coding workflows including QA; reviewing automated classifications; conducting calculations and analyses; maintaining analytical datasets; and preparing tables, charts, and other outputs.

4. Strengthen MEL workflows, data organization, and reporting

The consulting team will help make FOE's MEL processes more efficient, reproducible, and useful for program decision-making. This may include:

- Establishing consistent workflows for receiving, storing, cleaning, analyzing, quality-checking, and documenting MEL data.
- Developing or improving templates, protocols, and documentation for recurring analyses and review of AI-generated outputs.
- Identifying opportunities to automate recurring analyses, calculations, tables, charts, and other outputs.
- Improving organization of existing MEL datasets and analytical products.
- Identifying additional indicators that FOE could track to strengthen program learning, impact measurement, and funder reporting

The Senior Consultant will also help FOE scope and prioritize longer-term MEL needs that are not expected to be fully implemented through this engagement. These may include stronger approaches to assessing the program's contribution to district-level change; evaluation of FOE's youth program; and development of a more integrated MEL database, dashboard, or data-management system.

For these longer-term areas, the goal is to clarify objectives, requirements, methodological options, priorities, and appropriate next steps rather than fully implement new systems or evaluations.

Consultant Qualifications

Senior MEL & Evaluation Consultant

We are looking for a Senior Consultant with:

- At least 5 years of professional experience in measurement, evaluation, research, applied data analysis, or a closely related field.
- Demonstrated experience designing and implementing evaluations in real-world settings using imperfect or nonstandard administrative and program data.
- Strong quantitative skills and demonstrated ability to personally conduct and interrogate quantitative analyses using at least one statistical, programming, or analytical tool such as R, Python, Stata, SAS, SPSS, SQL, or comparable software.
- Strong understanding of counterfactual reasoning, sampling, sources of bias, and appropriate interpretation of observational data.

- Ability to translate methodological concepts into practical data-collection and implementation approaches for non-research partners.
- Experience directing and quality-assuring analytical work.
- Excellent analytical writing and communication skills, including translating complex findings for nontechnical audiences.
- Demonstrated ability to independently move complex analytical projects from planning through final deliverables.
- Familiarity with modern data-analysis workflows, including the opportunities and limitations of AI-supported analysis and coding tools.

Preferred:

- Experience with K–12 school nutrition, institutional foodservice, food procurement, food systems, or a related field.
- Familiarity with school meal operations and data, including menus, production records, recipes, purchasing/procurement records, and/or K–12-specific menu-planning, point-of-sale, procurement, or foodservice management software.
- Experience evaluating food, environmental, public health, education, or behavior-change programs.
- Experience in advocacy or nonprofit settings where evidence is used for program learning, communications, and policy change.

MEL Data Analyst

We are looking for a Data Analyst with:

- 1-3 years of professional experience in measurement, evaluation, research, applied data analysis, or a closely related field.
- Demonstrated experience cleaning, managing, analyzing, and quality-assuring complex quantitative datasets, including substantial experience working with messy or inconsistent real-world data.
- Strong spreadsheet skills and demonstrated proficiency using at least one statistical, programming, or analytical tool such as R, Python, Stata, SQL, SAS, SPSS, or comparable software to clean, manipulate, and analyze complex datasets.
- Ability to identify data-quality problems, investigate anomalies, reconcile inconsistencies, and document analytical decisions.
- Experience creating clear tables, charts, visualizations, and analytical outputs for nontechnical audiences.
- Strong attention to detail and commitment to data accuracy, documentation, and reproducibility.
- Curiosity about emerging AI tools and enthusiasm for experimenting with AI-assisted data cleaning, coding, analysis, automation, and quality assurance, while critically assessing and validating AI-generated outputs.
- Ability to work independently while collaborating closely with a senior evaluator or researcher.

Preferred:

- Experience using multiple analytical tools or programming languages, particularly Python, R, SQL, or comparable tools useful for automating and scaling recurring data workflows.
- Experience using AI-assisted coding or data-analysis workflows.
- Experience working with administrative, procurement, foodservice, education, or other operational datasets.
- Experience with K–12 school nutrition, institutional foodservice, food procurement, food systems, or related K–12 software.
- Experience supporting evaluations or applied research projects.

Anticipated Deliverables

Specific deliverables and timing will be finalized with the selected consultant(s) and prioritized within the available budget. Anticipated core deliverables include:

- **A MEL workplan and schedule of deliverables**, informed by the external MEL System Assessment and review of FOE's existing MEL framework, data, and analytical workflows.
- **Plant Powered Participation Pilot evaluation**, including an analysis and reporting plan, district-level findings and recommendations, cross-district analysis, and a final report with practical recommendations for future technical assistance, intervention design, and program strategy.
- **Annual school menu monitoring and reporting**, including review and strengthening of the existing methodology, quality assurance of AI-supported analysis, analysis of trends over time, and written and visual reporting of findings.
- **Production-record and recipe analyses** examining student selection and participation and associated costs, environmental impacts, and animal impacts.
- **Development and/or application of approaches to estimate broader environmental impacts**, including exploring how statewide menu monitoring can be combined with more detailed production-record and recipe data to estimate changes in greenhouse gas emissions associated with shifts in school meal offerings and student selection.
- **USDA Foods analysis and reporting** examining purchasing patterns.
- **Improved MEL infrastructure and workflows**, including QA protocols, analytical documentation, data organization, and more efficient and reproducible recurring analyses.
- **Recommendations for longer-term MEL priorities and capacity needs**, informed by the MEL System Assessment and learning from the engagement.

Contract Period, Hours, and Compensation

The anticipated contract period is **November 2026 through June 30, 2027**.

For planning and budgeting purposes, FOE estimates that the scope will require approximately **350 hours of Senior MEL & Evaluation Consultant support and 500 hours of MEL Data Analyst support over the contract period**. These estimates are intended to communicate the anticipated scale of the engagement rather than prescribe a weekly work schedule. Consultants will be responsible for proposing and allocating their time as needed to complete agreed-upon deliverables and milestones.

The workload is expected to vary over the contract period, particularly around 4P implementation, analysis, and reporting. The Senior Consultant will need sufficient availability to participate in mutually scheduled meetings with participating school districts during U.S. business hours.

FOE anticipates a **combined budget of approximately $80,000–$100,000**. Applicants may recommend a different allocation of hours between the Senior Consultant and Data Analyst if another structure would more efficiently accomplish the scope within the available budget.

Proposal Requirements

FOE has a preference for integrated team proposals but will consider individual applicants for either role.

Integrated teams should submit a brief description of their proposed approach; proposed team members and qualifications; division of responsibilities; relevant examples of similar work; proposed hours and rates for each team member; total budget; availability; and two to three references.

Individual applicants should identify the role for which they are applying and submit a brief description of relevant experience and approach; résumé or CV; relevant examples of similar work; proposed rate and anticipated hours; availability during the contract period; and two to three references.

FOE will evaluate proposals based on relevant experience; evaluation and analytical capabilities; ability to work with complex real-world data; methodological rigor and practical problem-solving; quality of written and analytical work; availability; cost and overall value; and, for integrated teams, the complementary skills and proposed division of responsibilities between the Senior Consultant and Data Analyst.

Applicants should submit requested materials by email to Chloe Waterman (cwaterman@foe.org) using the subject line "MEL Consultant Application" by Wednesday, October 14, 2026. We expect to interview candidates in late October, have finalists complete a technical exercise in early November, and onboard consultants by mid or late November.